

Fake Reviews, Hidden Fees and the DMCC Act

A plain-English guide for small UK online shops

The consumer-protection parts of the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act 2024 came into force on 6 April 2025. General information, not legal advice. Checked on 25 September 2026 against gov.uk and Competition and Markets Authority (CMA) guidance. Written with AI assistance and checked by a person.

Why it matters now

The CMA can now decide consumer-law breaches and fine businesses directly, up to **10% of global turnover or £300,000, whichever is higher**, without going to court first. Trading Standards still enforces too.

1. Fake reviews are banned

It is an automatically unfair practice to:

- ☐ Write, commission or buy reviews that don't reflect a genuine customer experience (including by friends, family or staff posing as customers)
- ☐ Offer incentives (discounts, freebies, entry into a draw) for reviews without making that clear in the review
- ☐ Hide or suppress negative reviews, or show only positive ones as if they were all of them
- ☐ Present reviews in a misleading way, e.g. star ratings merged from different products

If you publish reviews on your site you must take reasonable and proportionate steps to prevent and remove fake reviews. Have a short written review policy, check suspicious patterns, and don't edit reviews.

2. Drip pricing is banned

You can't show a headline price and add **unavoidable** charges later in checkout. Fixed mandatory fees (booking, admin or service fees) must be included in the first price the customer sees.

- ☐ Headline prices include every fixed fee the customer must pay
- ☐ Prices shown to consumers include VAT
- ☐ Delivery charges that vary (e.g. by location or speed) are clearly flagged up front, with how they're worked out, before the customer commits
- ☐ Optional extras are genuinely optional and not pre-ticked

3. Other things to check while you're at it

- ☐ Your business name, geographic address and email are on the site (Consumer Contracts Regulations)
- ☐ 14-day cancellation right for online orders explained, with the model cancellation form or an easy way to cancel
- ☐ Returns and refund policy that matches the Consumer Rights Act 2015
- ☐ Subscriptions: new rules on subscription contracts are being introduced separately; check gov.uk for the start date before changing your sign-up flow

4. A 15-minute self-audit

1. Open your product page as a new customer. Is the first price the price they'll pay, apart from clearly explained delivery?
2. Look at your reviews. Would you be comfortable explaining where each one came from?
3. Check your review request emails. Do any offer a reward only for positive reviews?
4. Read your footer and contact page. Are your name, address and email there?

Sources: DMCC Act 2024 Part 4; CMA "Unfair commercial practices" guidance (2025); gov.uk guidance for businesses on consumer law.